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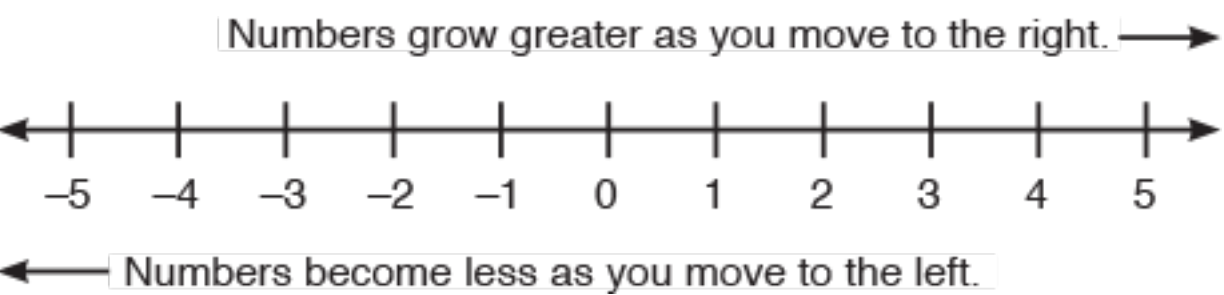
Comparing and Ordering Integers

An **integer** is any number in the following set: $\{\dots, -3, -2, -1, 0, 1, 2, 3, \dots\}$

The dots (...) on each end of the list show that the integers continue forever in both directions.

What numbers are not integers? Fractional quantities such as $\frac{3}{4}$, 0.75, and 30% are not integers because they represent part of a whole.

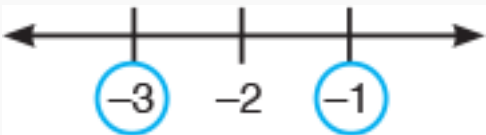
You can use a number line to decide whether one integer is greater than or less than another.



Example 1

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Which is greater, -3 or -1 ?
Find both integers on the number line.

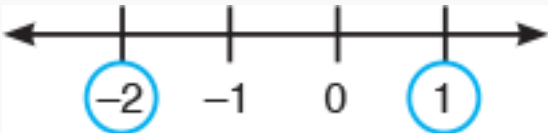


-1 is to the right of -3 , so **-1** is greater than -3 .

Example 2

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Which is less, -2 or 1 ?
Find both integers on the number line.



-2 is to the left of 1 , so **-2** is less than 1 .

Thinking about the number line will help you avoid mistakes. For example, you are used to thinking that 8 is greater than 5, so you might also think that -8 is greater than -5 . However, the opposite is true. Because -5 is to the right of -8 on the number line, -5 is greater. If you aren't sure of an answer, try sketching a number line.

To compare the values of numbers, use the symbols shown here.

Symbol	Meaning	Example
=	is equal to	$7 = 7$
<	is less than	$-4 < 6$
>	is greater than	$5 > 2$

Tip

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To remember the difference between $<$ and $>$, think of each symbol as an arrow that points to the smaller number.

$2 < 5 \quad 5 > 2$

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Category
Lesson 1: Number Sense

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